



## CHETWODE BUILDING



necessary to obtain recruits of the right stamp and to maintain them in such a degree of comfort and dignity as will shield them from temptation and keep them efficient for their term of service and prevent them from leaving." None of these criteria is being met.

Since 2004, 2,877 officers—1,095 in the last year alone—have sought premature retirement and 1,694 have quit. What seems like a small drop in a 34,000-strong officer cadre is in fact worrying. From commanding a battalion to wearing a general's epaulettes—easily the highest privileges—nothing seems attractive enough. "Not only are we burning the candle from both ends but also from the middle," says a senior army official. Even the traditional feeders—the 19 Sainik Schools, five military schools and the Rashtriya

**WEAK COMMAND:** IMA reported an intake of 34 per cent of its capacity Indian Military Academy—which used to produce over 2,000 eligible youth every year, seem to be drying up, due in part to myopic policies. Fees at the Sainik Schools has quadrupled in the past eight years to cross Rs 40,000 per year. So instead of rectifying class imbalances—the reason the schools were conceived in 1961—they are now out of the reach of the weaker sections.

The army's inability to add 2,100 new officer-recruits every year comes at a time when a single IT firm, Infosys, adds 19,000 employees in a financial year. It is not just the money. Experts warn that the Sixth Pay Commission's recommendations may not be enough to end the woes of the army. The army's campaigns have failed to appeal to the target audience. "It's hard to believe that a nation of one billion cannot find 2,000 officers in a year for the army. Students are interested, but not enough is being done to tap schools," says Vice-Admiral (retired) S.C.S. Bangara, a former NDA commandant.

**T**his year, the army has doubled its intake of short service commission (ssc) officers—who are trained for 10 months and serve the force for a minimum of five years—from 500 in 2004. Still, ssc entries constitute only 20 per cent of the army's present strength, whereas armies of the developed world, which, like the Indian army, are scouring white-collar industry for talent, are largely made up of short-serving officers. What the Indian Army has done, however, is to try and incentivise sscs by increasing the remuneration. Its recommendations to the Pay Commission include giving ssc officers Rs 1 lakh as loyalty bonus at the end of every year of service. More such steps are needed to increase the intake of ssc officers to make up for the current shortfall. "The army should shorten their stint to two years and train them within three months for specific tasks," suggests Singh. "These officers should be allowed to leave after the period of compulsory service. This will inject young blood into the army," he adds. Clearly, the army needs more such booster shots in its hour of need. ■

### HOW TO WIN THEM

■ **Double the salaries of officers**

■ **Make short service commission more attractive. Give Rs 1 lakh as loyalty bonus for every year of service rendered.**

■ **Consider shorter terms of service to infuse young blood**

■ **Energise National Cadet Corps, lower fees in Sainik Schools and other traditional feeder institutions**

■ **Launch an all-out campaign to target more schools across the country and appeal to the youth**